



NO YARD OF LAND WAS LEFT OUT

THE DOMESDAY BOOK (1086)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Land tenure

BEFORE

1066 William of Normandy conquers England.

1069–1070 In the “Harrying of the North,” William puts down a revolt and large-scale land confiscations follow.

AFTER

1166 Henry II instructs his tenants-in-chief to compile the *Cartae Baronum*, a new list of lands held by current tenants-in-chief and their subtenants.

1334 Tenants-in-chief of the Welsh Marches claim that the Marches are not subject to English tax because the Domesday Book describes them as “in Wales.”

1977 Ancient Domesne Courts that adjudicated on the basis of royal land-holdings in the Domesday Book are abolished, except as ceremonial bodies.

Following his invasion of England in 1066, William the Conqueror, now King William I, made frequent visits to his home duchy of Normandy, leaving writs (written instructions) in his absence. However, the wholesale change of landownership that had followed the conquest had not been well documented, risking legal and administrative chaos. William desired a fuller account of his new royal demesne (landed property) in England and—being in urgent need of money—he needed to ascertain the total yield of rents.

Compiling Domesday

In December 1085, the king sent out commissioners to establish who owned each estate and each one's productive value (even down to the number of ducks on the land). In each area, a sworn jury of local landowners and villagers reported to the commissioners. The findings were then gathered into summaries and returned to Westminster Palace. There they were bound together in 1086 into the first draft of what we now know as the Domesday Book. (The book was as binding as the Christian Day of Judgment, or “Doomsday.”)

William died in 1087, before he put the Domesday census to use, but it was of huge value. Virtually all of England had been mapped administratively and lordship and land-holding were now inseparable, reflecting the new political structure.

The king's land

Before the Norman Conquest, English property law had presumed that the land had no single owner, such as a king. So individuals had been able to own a parcel of land

This most powerful king sent his justices through every shire ... of England, and caused an inquiry to be made by sworn inquest how many hides ... there were in each village, and what livestock.

Henry of Huntingdon

English historian
(c. 1088–c. 1157)